



Cheering for their leader

Ho Chi Minh is feted by his colleagues at the congress that founded the Workers' Party of Vietnam in 1951, during the war against France. He frequently changed the name of the party organization in order to obscure his unswerving communist affiliation.

Police state

As leader of North Vietnam from 1955, Ho presided over a state that left no room for individual freedom and ruthlessly imposed its system on a reluctant peasantry. He was still leader in 1959, when the North Vietnamese politburo took the decision to resume war to achieve the goal of a united communist Vietnam, but was superseded by Le Duan in 1960. Ho continued to have some influence on the conduct of the war until 1965, after which he was largely a figurehead, though he played a part in advising North Vietnam's peace negotiators. The simplicity of his personal habits and his absolute lack of corruption sustained an image of purity and dignity that won respect among his people. His death in 1969 provoked a tremendous outpouring of grief.